

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Open Source

We've all heard about the Open Source Software (OSS) movement, but how much do we really know about it? In case your friends know more than you, here are a few terms that should see you through that uncomfortable conversation.

GPL: The GNU General Public License is too complicated to explain in such a small space. However, to give you an idea, the GPL is the most popular license for free and OSS. It allows users to copy, modify and distribute software that is under GPL for free, or even for money. However, source code of such modified software *has* to be included.

Repository: OSS is developed by hundreds and thousands of people from across the globe. In order for them to all be able to work together, all the source code needs to be stored in one globally accessible server. This server is called a repository, and contains all the different versions of the software being developed.

CVS: The Concurrent Versioning System was until recently the most popular version control system in place. It's now being replaced by SVN.

SVN: Short for Subversion, this is the revision control (or version control) system that is becoming popular. This version control software offers more advanced features than CVS, which are needed when thousands of developers are working on the same source code.

FSF: The Free Software Foundation is the group that is spearheading the OSS and Freeware movement. They support the GNU and help with legal issues in the OSS domain.

Usage: "I wish Microsoft would release Windows 98 under GPL. I'd like to see the CVS/SVN repositories for the blue-screen, and watch as the FSF tries to convince them to take it back!"

Wild Wild Web

The Love Bug

February is the month of love, and Google loves us, too, even if we don't click on the ads. And as you know, Google changes their homepage logo on various occasions, and on St. Valentine's Day they tried something lovely: a cherry dipped in chocolate, making up a letter "g". For whatever reason, they forgot the "l". Which is sad because "L" could stand for "Love," and it might have indicated that they've stopped loving us.

Someone wrote to Google's Corporate Communication Co-

ordinator about the missing "L". He also helpfully asked the C.C.C. whether the green stalk on the strawberry was for "L".

The Corp. Comm. Coordinator simply agreed with the reader, and replied that it was Google's new "edgy" design. She ended her reply with an "L". Standing for "Love," of course—so we're happy again.

Virtual Swedish Embassy

Sweden's Pirate Heaven, so lots of people want to move there. Many people don't know the processes involved. So, the Government launched its



officially-sanctioned embassy in the virtual space of Second Life, known as the Swedish Institute. We're making much of this up, mind you, but not the part about the Institute. The Institute will tell would-be movers to Sweden how to get passports and visas in this, the real world. It is now looking towards buying an island to create a home for Swedish companies in Second Life. Reminiscent of Sealand, that...

display porn ads—because of the "pecker" in the name, of course. Now wait; johnpecker.com is a placeholder site, but there's no tompecker.com or harrypecker.com or even a dickpecker.com! So, funnily enough, there's this bloke called Ferris who registered davidpecker.com some time ago. Pecker and Ferris attempted to negotiate; it climbed to \$1,600, and finally Ferris demanded \$15,000 to stop registering other domain names with "pecker" in them.

We're wondering why Ferris chose *david* as part of the domain name to register—and why he hasn't registered more common peckers like, as we said, dickpecker. And, in the first place, who would head to a site that simply had "pecker" in the name somewhere, assuming it would be a good porn site? Ferris' motives remain a mystery, but that's the way it works. He held control of his rights simply by linking "pecker" to porn—which leads to interesting observations:

willy.com is the "WILLY ITALIANA" website." They manufacture garment labels. wiener.com is "Wiener Reviews," and they go, "Wiener revies (sic) is dedicated to the gay community!"

Although whang.com and dong.com and schlong.com are parked, the usual suspects, which we won't mention here, are all porn sites.

The possibilities are many in this domain (pun not intended), but the point is, if you've got a porn-related name like that of John Gay the poet, your chances of getting "your" domain are slim!

I'M BEAUTIFUL

Profiles Lie

You've probably heard a story that goes like this—it might have happened to a friend or colleague or even you: an online friend of the opposite sex is tall and handsome (or beautiful), but he or she hasn't posted a photo yet. (That digicam is always waiting to be bought, and he or she doesn't have a scanner!) Then comes personal meeting day. And one goes, "He (or she) was better online." Research now points out that more than 90 per cent of online daters lie about at least one thing in their profiles.

The biggest—and the most frequent—lies are about height and weight, just what you'd expect. This comes

from Michigan State University research. (Yes, a lot of such time-pass research is state-funded in America.)

There are very precise figures: in the MSU research, it turned out that men say they're an inch taller than they are, women in their twenties say they're five pounds less weighty, and women in their thirties say they're 17 pounds less weighty.

People even lie about being married, though we think that isn't too common in India.

Interestingly, there are "spikes" in ages on online profiles—for example, the spike at "29", which you could figure for yourself. There also happens to be a spike at "36"—the figure for that age is much higher than that for "between 37 and 41." Hence, we figure, 37 is "old."

So why do people lie? The researchers found pretty much what we knew: that the Internet disinhibits you, that you feel free to say what you want; also, that you want to attract a more appealing partner. For men, lying about income is practical: people listing higher incomes just get more responses! It's quite pardonable, really: get hitched to someone online, and confess on meeting day.